18th ESPI Autumn Conference

AC|2024

Key Takeaways

Conference Key Takeaway

With the backdrop of war in Europe and its immediate neighbourhood, the continent is increasingly aware of past strategic failures to ensure a future-proof suite of space capabilities for its security and defence needs. The 18th edition of ESPI's Autumn Conference explored **how Europe could better leverage and further develop the existing space ecosystem to meet security challenges, military needs and political appetites.**



The conference, held on October 1st and 2nd in Vienna, welcomed 250 attendees from a broad spectrum of the space security and defence ecosystem from across 22 countries. On top, two additional ESPI-organised events took place in synergy with the conference.

On September 30th, ESPI organised the first **Roundtable of European Space Commands and Ministries of Defence,** providing a platform for exchanges on current challenges and best practices among military space actors. The platform aims to foster exchange between national space commands to help increasing cooperation and information sharing. This dialogue was further pursued during the conference through Session 2, "Military Space Perspectives".

Moreover, as announced during Session 1 "Think Tank Perspectives", ESPI launched the **Network of European Space Policy Think Tanks (NEST)** with a dedicated Launch Event on October 2nd. NEST aims to provide a platform for exchanges and cooperation between think tanks, aiming to multiply reach and increase impact of recommendations for policy makers.

Attendees and speakers recognised an immediate need to level-up the political will, called for leveraging strengths within existing institutional and industrial frameworks and proposed creating a federated & more integrated framework for civil, commercial & military cooperation at national and European level. A selection of key takeaways is presented below.

7 KEY TAKEAWAYS



1 Triggering the Alert: Rising Threats Outpacing Europe's Response Framework

Space is now firmly established as an operational domain of warfare and is increasingly crucial for maintaining national security within and outside European borders. With this evolution, threats to European space assets and their service multiply and proliferate at an unprecedented pace. Jamming and spoofing of GNSS systems was considered among the most prevalent threats alongside the (intentional) generation of space debris.

Europe must, as a crucial first step, **prioritise the identification of threats through effective domain awareness, which is the groundwork for future reactions, deterrence, resilience, and ultimately counteractions.** Today, Europe still lacks a common understanding of space threats and especially grey areas of operations in space - which negatively impacts its ability to appropriately react

As the current threat assessment performed on a case-by-case basis is not sufficient, a solution proposed in the conference is a **multi-step approach and a matrix system for threat assessments and response,** which integrates military and civilian perspectives, while also considering the decision chain and hierarchy within military structures.

2 Avoiding the Snooze Button: Urgent Needs Meet a Capability Gap

The war in Ukraine served as a wake-up call for Europe to understand the role space plays in modern-day conflict. While the wake-up call is reflected in a host of national policy documents and the EU Space Strategy for Security and Defence (EU SSSD), **Europe still lacks the political will to legitimately implement its announced strategic ambitions** in space security & defence.

In this context, the **urgency to accelerate Europe's approach to space security and defence and to develop a more integrated dual-use space architecture remains critical.**

Inherently linked to the insufficient political will and resulting in limited and slow implementation, the conference's discussions underscored the persistent lack of funding and highlighted its direct hampering effect on Europe's ability to develop capabilities to efficiently act and react to security and defence threats in a timely (i.e. immediate) manner.





3 Readying for Yesterday: Aligning Europe's Capabilities with its Declared Ambitions

While unified purpose and direction are essential to establish an ambition, European capabilities are crucial to implement it and more importantly meet today's acute operational needs. **Space capabilities for security and defence should therefore primarily be defined as a function of what military actors need to deter and respond to threats,** providing the means to conduct military operations.

It is essential to **systematically raise awareness on the needs of dedicated entities responsible for military space** (e.g., space commands) and to fill the gaps by addressing them as soon as possible.

Finally, it is key to reflect on the processes involved in **integrating military requirements into new space programmes, which should be clear and from the outset and embedded by design.** IRIS2 was quoted as an example where military applications were not clear at the beginning, and military actors left out in its requirements design phase, adding complexities into the advancements of dual-use programmes and processes.

Broadly speaking, the **need for boosting capabilities and leveraging existing programmes, expertise, and know-how cannot be overstated.**







4 All Hands on Deck: Strengthening Bilateral, EU, ESA and NATO Cooperation

While for some countries, a solid foundation of domestic capabilities is necessary to ensure national sovereignty, no single country can expect to do it all on its own. **Effective cooperation requires alignment of national budgets, investments, and priorities, while strengthening Europe's industrial policy. Coordinated efforts across the EU, NATO, ESA, and member states are vital for Europe's collective security.**

To do so, **artificial barriers between civil & defence programmes have to be dismantled and the dual-use nature of all space activities fully recognised and leveraged.**

It is therefore essential to integrate national and EU's priorities, initiatives and funding, with ESA capability development and R&D programmes, and NATO's long-term plans to weave a resilient collective security framework, with the UK as a key partner. In this context it was shared that ESA's involvement in dual-use R&D and military applications is well established, with support to ESA's dual-use programmes contributing toward the 2% national defence budget target for NATO.

5 Merging the Lanes: Integrating Civil and Military Efforts

Europe needs to establish a smoother framework for civil commercial-military cooperation and commercial integration. While the concept is long-discussed, limited progress has been made on actually leveraging commercial solutions.

This is (i.a.) a function of commercial companies not necessarily differentiating between military or civil users, prioritising cost efficiency, while institutional actors mandated with security & defence focus on resilience and reliability. To fully embrace the opportunity trust-building needs to take centre stage, as **industry needs to ascertain longer-term demand to invest towards more resilience, while institutional actors need to revise its requirements depending on mission criticality,** to lower entry barriers for innovative companies and solutions.

To **ensure longer-term demand novel practices for security procurement were proposed, discarding project-based procurement, and replacing it with a longer demand-outlook, and stocking up to reduce strategic weaknesses.** Such an approach will also enable increased industrial co-financing and risk taking, as well as (most importantly) secure a healthier industrial base, a prerequisite for any security and defence ambitions.

Finally, as many countries lack the necessary know-how and expertise for space-related procurement, it is **crucial to leverage existing institutions with space expertise** to manage such programmes, ensuring smooth delivery, developing minimum service & product requirements, and foster next-generation innovation.









6 Huddle Up:
Developing Talent and Leadership for Europe's Space Security & Defence

Beyond the establishment of space commands, there is a wide understanding of the increasing need to create dedicated units for dealing with space, as part of operational military entities. Today, these entities have two main responsibilities. First, the more prevalent and traditional role of supporting ground operations through space-based services. The second role is newer and less common in Europe, focused on operations in space, protecting and managing space-based assets and ensuring that they can support military and civilian operations.

European military space entities are currently facing a **pressing need to train personnel and develop expertise within their units, with demand for skilled professionals growing rapidly, reflected in staffing plans of established military commands.** Beyond technical roles establishing strong, **politically savvy leadership to spearhead the development of new capabilities and frameworks is equally key** to navigate the complex governance landscape and budgetary challenges.

To overcome some of these challenges, **training programs and intra-European personnel exchanges have emerged as priority areas,** enabling knowledge-sharing and capacity-building. Finally, **conducting joint exercises with allied forces** will help enhance operational readiness and collaboration in addressing space-based threats.



7 Turning the Tide:
Strong Europe as a Partner to the World

The acute lack of strategic autonomy leaves the continent as a less desired partner to countries and regions outside our immediate neighbourhood, limiting the influence and strategic leverage that Europe could assert based on its potential. Combining stronger capabilities for space security & defence, combined with Europe's existing status as a trusted partner could turn the tide, **establish Europe as a partner of choice for middle powers, and increase its international posture.**

It was noted that today, despite targeted efforts and investment, Europe is only perceived as the 4th economic and strategic power in the ASEAN region well behind China and the United States, with a clear drop in year-on-year scores. This is considered as a function of misaligned and non-coordinated activities whereby political priorities are not embedded alongside development cooperation and financing.

Europe should therefore **double down & lead the charge in middle power cooperation in space security & defence, breaking bipolar power dynamics, and leverage its newly acquired strategic advantage to bolster its existing alliances and established partnerships.**





